

6.2.4 Persons with Physical and Mental Disabilities

For each type of functional domain considered, the level of difficulty reported by an individual was used to identify persons with disabilities. If an individual reported “a lot of difficulty” or “cannot do at all” for any functionality, then they were classified as a person with a disability. An individual may have one or more disabilities.

Accordingly, 727,293 persons aged 5 years and over were identified having at least one disability under 6 functional domains: seeing, hearing, walking or climbing steps, remembering or concentrating, performing daily activities independently, and communicating with others. Any individual with at least one disability is included in this count. Expressed as a rate, this corresponds to 35 persons with a disability per 1,000 individuals aged 5 years and over in Sri Lanka.

Table 6.2.4 : Distribution of Persons Aged 5 Years and Over with Disabilities by Sex and Domain of Disability, 2024

		Total	Male	Female
Total population aged 5 years and over	Number	20,566,680	9,901,263	10,665,417
Population aged 5 years and over with at least one disability	Number	727,293	313,354	413,939
	Rate (per 1,000 persons)	35	32	39
Domain of Disability		Total	Male	Female
Seeing	Number	192,578	80,696	111,882
	Rate (per 1,000 persons)	9	8	10
Hearing	Number	130,097	57,221	72,876
	Rate (per 1,000 persons)	6	6	7
Walking or climbing steps	Number	447,969	180,620	267,349
	Rate (per 1,000 persons)	22	18	25
Remembering or concentrating on something	Number	167,826	75,051	92,775
	Rate (per 1,000 persons)	8	8	9
Selfcare, such as washing all over or dressing	Number	189,292	84,428	104,864
	Rate (per 1,000 persons)	9	9	10
Communicating with others	Number	112,798	55,333	57,465
	Rate (per 1,000 persons)	5	6	5

According to Table 6.2.4, the highest number of persons (447,969) were reported to have walking or climbing disability. This corresponds to 22 persons per 1,000 individuals aged 5 years and over. Further, the lowest number of persons (112,798) were reported to have disability in communicating with others. For all domains of disabilities, except communication the number and rate of females having disabilities are higher compared to those of males.